I view the 1980s as where the greatest changes in the modern woodturning world took place, building on the momentum of the 70s. High speed steel tools, one key scroll chucks, lathes of infinitely variable speeds; the equipment was light years ahead of what had been available previously. National turning organizations were formed, international seminars were organized world wide, the 'Collectors of Wood Art' was established, an avalanche of quality publications were produced and videos on turning were released. Along with all of these developments came a new phenomenon: a willingness to share information. For years trade secrets were guarded, which probably held back the development of turning for years. Fortunately there were enough who were enlightened, to spark the creativity we see today. In this article I will focus on some of the major players and my experiences of being part of some ground-breaking events.

The late Tony Walker of Sorby Tools once told me his ambition was to de-skill woodturning. From my point of view, much of his ambition has been achieved. In sharpening and vessel hollowing for example, there is a plethora of jigs on the market which can short cut the hand-eye coordination skills previously required. These innovations have given those in later life the opportunity to make work that they could have only have dreamed of if they had to learn all the skills previously required. There are many such innovations that are meritorious, while others leave a lot to be desired. Remember that the latest set of golf clubs endorsed by a legend will not make you a better golfer; it is the same in woodturning. At the end of the day, it is down to your level of skill and creativity.

1981

This was a huge year for the modern turning movement. Albert LeCoff and Palmer Sharpless had previously been organizing small seminars twice a year with five demonstrators for 70 or so participants, at the George School outside Philadelphia. Albert decided to organize a final seminar in 1981, bringing together all the past demonstrators for the occasion. This was a must-attend event for me. I approached the British Council for help towards the air fare and they said if I received a letter of invitation to demonstrate, they would contribute. Albert generously invited me to demonstrate. Once I told Richard Raffan of my deal, he was soon on board under the same arrangement and we travelled there together. This seminar proved to be the most significant event in either of our turning lives up to that time.

We met up with the who's who of US creative woodturning on the day prior to the seminar starting; we all shared stories and got to know one another. It seemed we had entered the world of giants, all standing 6ft 2in or taller: David Ellsworth, Bruce Mitchell, Bill Hunter, Skip Johnson, Leo Doyle, Frank Cummings, Ed Moulthrop, Giles Gilson. There were those smaller in stature, though not in ability or their contribution to the modern turning movement, also in attendance: Del Stubbs, Dale Nish, Mark Lindquist, Bob Stocksdale, Al Stirt, Stephen Hogbin. Richard and I were welcomed with open arms. As Richard and I travelled over, he confided he had a shaky offer to write a turning book for Batsford's. He decided it might be worth speaking with John Kelsey of Taunton Press, who we knew would be at the event. Kelsey suggested he outlined what he had in mind and write a chapter.
The rest is history; Richard has become the most successful published woodturning author of the past 30 years.

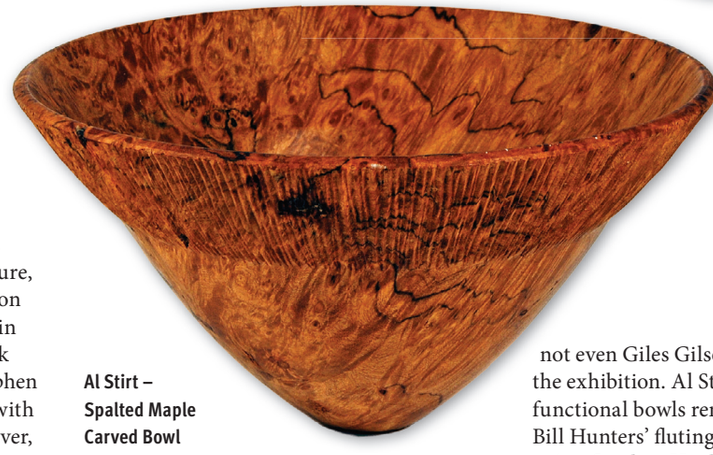
The event proved to be far more successful than either of our wildest dreams; opportunities abounded and our mastery of technique and ability to communicate while still turning was greatly appreciated. Mike Hosaluk, unknown at the time, was in attendance as delegate: his work in the gallery stood out instantly and he has now become one of the most creative forces on the world stage, travelling widely and passing on his unique skills.

The work at this time was still focused mostly on the beauty of the material; not even Giles Gilson had painted pieces in the exhibition. Al Stirt was flute carving his functional bowls reminiscent of ceramics. Bill Hunters' fluting was shallow at this point. Stephen Hogbin's deconstructing and re-assembling was about as radical things got. Probably the most controversial piece was Merryll Saylan's segment constructed Jelly Doughnut, with an acrylic segment in red: no one would bat an eyelid today but at the time it was the source of much heated discussion.

Richard and I met Dale Nish for the first time at this event. We had both been in communication previously as he had invited us to be part of his book *Master Woodturners*

Bruce Mitchell (1981) – Bay Leaf Laurel Vessel

Mike Hosaluk – Bird Vessel



Al Stirt – Spalted Maple Carved Bowl

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